

Session 24: Key Takeaways From the Eden Story

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew words for help and skin look very similar. It’s as if the animal skin that God provides to cover the humans is a diminished form of God’s ‘ezer (help) in the broken reality after the failure of the humans.
- God responds to human failure with mercy. God continues to work with humanity even in the midst of brokenness.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 3:20-21

Eve’s Name and a Divine Mercy

²⁰ and the human **called** the name of his woman "Hawwah",
"for she is the mother of all **living** (חַיִּים)"

²¹ and God made for human and his wife, garments of skin,
and he clothed them.

Genesis 3:20-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

These two verses seem randomly placed here, but they are actually strategically located in order to create a frame around the entire fail narrative of Genesis 3:1-19 by matching and inverting multiple elements in Genesis 2:18-25.

Genesis 2:18-25	Genesis 3:1-19	Genesis 3:20-21
1. Adam names the woman “woman”	The snake, the woman, and the man	1. Adam names the woman “Hawwah”
2. God provides woman as an ‘ezer (עֹזֵר)		2. The deception of the ‘ezer (עֹזֵר) creates the need for “skin” (עֹר)
Comparing Genesis 2:18-25 to Genesis 3:20-21. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).		

Genesis 2:18-25			Genesis 3:1-19			Genesis 3:20-21		
3. They are naked and not ashamed						3. Human nakedness is covered by God		
4. Humanity at peace with the animals						4. An animal is killed to “clothe” humans		
<i>Comparing Genesis 2:18-25 to Genesis 3:20-21. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).</i>								

After the failure of the man and woman, the story concludes with these two short details. The naming of the woman in 2:23 is now furthered by a dual wordplay.

1. She is named “Eve” (Heb. *hawwah* / חוה for she is the mother of all “life” (Heb. *hay* / חי).
2. The semitic root *hawwah* also means “snake” in Jewish Aramaic (חוויה) and Syriac (see Kohler-Baumgartner, *Hebrew and Aramaic Lexicon of the Old Testament*, 296).

God provides “garments of skin (עור)” to replace the “leaf garments” the humans made to hide their nakedness from each other. This last word (“garments of skin”) is a wordplay on God’s provision of the woman as a deliverance of help for the man (עזר).

The provision of garments for the humans happens before their expulsion from Eden and is portrayed as an act of divine generosity in the midst of judgment. Now that the humans have made the irreversible decision, God accommodates their non-ideal situation and provides them with a gift. And this “garment” (Heb. *ketonet* / כתנת) is not just a tunic but a robe (Joseph’s technicolor dream coat in Gen. 37:3 is a *ketonet* as well).

This scene also plants the seed of a key motif in the book of Genesis: deception and garments. In the Eden story, the snake’s deception of the naked woman results in her need for a garment. Let’s look at this motif in later biblical stories.

- Rebekah and Jacob trick Isaac with deceptive garments and food ([Gen. 27:15-17](#)).
- Joseph’s brothers deceive Jacob with a bloodied garment ([Gen. 37:31-33](#)).
- Tamar deceives Judah by “covering” herself with deceptive garments ([Gen. 38:14](#)).
- Joseph is elevated from prison and gets new garments ([Gen. 41:42](#)) that disguise him from his brothers so that he can deceptively get them to tell the truth ([Gen. 42:8; 43:1-44:34](#)).

This provision of garments for the one God exiles from Eden is also reversed in Israel’s priesthood. They are also assigned “divine garments (Heb. *ketonet*)” by God which will cover their nakedness when they work at the altar or enter the tabernacle ([Exod. 21:26; 28:39-43](#)).

Conclusion of the Eden Narrative: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 3:22-24

Exile From Eden

22 And Yahweh God said,
"Look, the human has become like one of us, **knowing good and bad**,
and now so that he won't send out his hand and take also from **the tree of life (חיים)**,
and eat and **live (חי)** forever ..."

23 and Yahweh God **sent him out** from the garden
to work the ground from which he was taken

24a and he **banished** the human

24b and he made to dwell at the **east of the garden of Eden**
cherubim and the flame of the whirling sword to guard way to **the tree of life (חיים)**.

Genesis 3:20-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

This concluding unit represents the inversion of the Eden story's introduction.

- God created the human and placed him in the garden. > The human is banished from the garden.
- God causes the tree of life and knowing good and bad to grow. > Humans are cut off from them.
- Before the garden there was no human to work the ground. > The human works the ground outside Eden.
- Humanity was made mortal so that by obeying God they could remain in the garden and receive the gift of eternal life. > Now they are cut off and sent into the land of mortality.
- Humanity was directed to guard/keep the garden. > Humanity is now guarded/kept from the garden.

The story's final line about the cherubim and "flame of the whirling sword" is a condensed hint that sends the reader forward to the design of the tabernacle and temple and into the prophetic visions of the divine throne room. Cherubim flank the ark of the covenant on the holy of holies ([Exod. 25:17-22](#)). In the temple, cherubim are designed on the walls of the holy place and on the front doors into the temple ([1 Kgs. 6:29-32](#)). The "sword" will appear in the hand of the angel of Yahweh again when David goes to the hilltop in Jerusalem, which at the time was the threshing floor of Ornan ([1 Chron. 21:16](#)).

Key Takeaways From the Eden Story in Genesis 2:4-3:24

God's ideal for creation is for his transcendent and eternal life-giving presence (Heaven) to be united with our material creation (Earth) so that it is transformed into eternal life.

Eden is the key biblical image of the place where Heaven and Earth are one. It is both Heaven and Earth simultaneously, as are the tabernacle and the Jerusalem temple. This is why garden and temple imagery pervades Heaven imagery throughout the Bible.

Outside of Eden, the reality of Heaven on Earth is hidden from us most of the time. However, we experience its gifts of blessing in every baby's birth, in every abundant harvest, in every good meal, in every experience of beauty and laughter, and in every feeling of intimacy and communion with family or someone we love.

These gifts of Eden are small tastes of ultimate goodness that pervade our world and point humanity to their creator if they have eyes to see.

The story of Genesis 3 is more about “the fail” than “the fall.” It is about a misguided attempt to seize divine wisdom.

“Wisdom is good, and we can safely assume that God did not intend to withhold it from humanity. But true wisdom must be acquired through a process, generally from instruction by those who are wise. The fall is defined by the fact that Adam and Eve acquired wisdom illegitimately (Gen. 3:22), thus trying to take God’s role for themselves rather than eventually joining God in his role as they were taught wisdom and became the fully functional vice-regents of God involved in the process of bringing order. If humans are to work alongside of God in extending order (‘subdue’ and ‘rule’ [Gen. 1:28]), they need to attain wisdom, but as endowment from God, not by seizing it for autonomous use. If ... from the start people were mortal, and pain and suffering were already a part of a not yet fully ordered cosmos, we cannot think of death and suffering as having been foisted on us by Adam and Eve’s malfeasance. ... Instead, we can have a much more charitable attitude toward Adam and Eve when we realize that it is not that they initiated a situation that was not already there; it is that they failed to achieve a solution ... that was in their reach. Their choices resulted in their failure to acquire relief on our behalf. Their failure meant that we are doomed to death and a disordered world full of sin. These are profoundly significant consequences for what was a serious offense. In contrast, Christ was able to achieve the desired result where Adam and Eve failed. We are all doomed to die because when they sinned we lost access to the tree of life. We are therefore subject to death because of sin. Christ succeeded and actually provided the remedy to sin and death. Some would follow this same line of reasoning to suggest that what we call original sin is the result of our ancestors “pulling out of the program” prematurely. James Gaffney identifies these approaches as involving a view that our human condition is underdeveloped, failing to achieve the intended goal because we wanted to do it our way—not paradise lost, but, as it were, paradise ungained.”

Walton, John (2015). [*The Lost World of Adam and Eve: Genesis 2-3 and the Human Origins Debate*](#). IVP Academic.

Evil is a semi-personal presence that causes doubt about the creator’s goodness and intentions, and it compels humans to declare themselves to be the author of both their own identity and of good and evil. This results in a tragic irony where humans give their divine dignity over to creation with its animal-like appetite for survival and control.

The story sets up the main plot conflict that drives the rest of the biblical story: God wanted to rule creation through his human images, but now they are in rebellion and causing chaos and disorder in God’s good world. So what’s the solution? We need a new kind of human who can do two things we cannot do for ourselves: Deal with the problem humanity has generated, and restore humanity back to its ideal role.

Reflection Question

God doesn’t stop working in and with humanity after he banishes them from the garden. What does this show us about God’s heart? What should we expect from God as we continue reading Genesis and the rest of the Bible?